Copilot at work: the prompts

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Goal
What you want done. "Draft a reply to the customer."

Context
The situation. "One task will finish three days late."

Source
Where to look. "Use the project plan and the meeting notes."

Expectations
The shape. "Under 150 words, professional tone, end with next steps."

COPILOT CHAT

Tighten an answer. Shorten that to three bullet points. A follow-up builds on the answer above it. You do not start over.

Change the audience. Rewrite it for a customer audience. Say who will read it and the tone follows.

Narrow the focus. Use the same source, but focus only on risks and next steps. Keeps the source, changes the question.

Catch up after time away. I was away for the past week. Summarize what happened in this chat. List key decisions, open questions, and action items. Include the owner for each action item if it is mentioned. Name the span of time and ask for owners.

Prepare for tomorrow's meeting. Prepare me for tomorrow's meeting. Use the meeting invite, the related email thread, and the notes from the last meeting. Summarize the background, key topics, unresolved issues, and questions I may want to ask. Name the three sources so it does not pick its own.

Find a detail across your work. When did someone first propose the current project timeline? Show me where you found it. Ask for the source and open it before you repeat the detail.

Find the latest version of a file. Where is the latest version of the project plan file, and who changed it last? Copilot only finds files you can already open.

Find what a customer asked for. What did the customer ask for last month about this project? List each request with the email or meeting it came from. One request per line, each with its source.

Ask where a claim came from. Where did that figure come from? Show me the source. Ask whenever a number or date surprises you.

OUTLOOK

Draft a status email. Draft an email to the team about the project status. The project is on schedule, but one task will finish three days late. Use the project plan and the notes from the weekly team meeting. Keep it under 150 words, use a professional tone, and include clear next steps. All four ingredients: goal, context, source, expectations.

Summarize a long email thread. Summarize this thread. What was decided, what is still open, and what do I need to do? Ask for decisions and actions, not just a summary.

Draft a reply to a customer. Draft a reply to the customer. Thank them for the update, confirm our team is reviewing the project, and let them know we will share the next steps by Friday. Use a professional tone and keep it to about 150 words. State the tone and the length every time.

Make a reply shorter and firmer. Make this shorter and firmer. Keep it under 75 words and clearly state the Friday deadline. A follow-up on the draft above.

Check a draft against its sources. Check this draft against the source emails. Verify customer names, project names, dates, and commitments. Flag anything that may be incorrect. Then open the sources yourself. This is a second pair of eyes, not the last word.

TEAMS

Catch up on a chat you missed. Summarize this conversation. What decisions were made, what questions are still open, and what actions should I be aware of? Works in a chat or a channel.

Recap a meeting you missed. Summarize this meeting. List the decisions that were made, the action items with owners, and any open questions that still need answers. Needs a meeting that was recorded or transcribed.

Ask during a meeting. What has been decided so far, and what risks have been mentioned? Only when transcription is on. Nobody hears you ask.

Send the summary to attendees. Draft a message to the attendees with the meeting summary and action items. Ask owners to confirm their assignments. Read it once as an attendee before you send.

WORD

Summarize a document for managers. Create an executive summary of this document. The audience is department managers who need a quick update before a review meeting. Use the attached document as the source. Limit the summary to five bullet points and highlight risks, progress, and decisions. Name the audience and the length, or you get a generic summary.

Draft a document from notes. Create a first draft of a project update based on these notes. Include a short summary, progress so far, current risks, and next steps for the team and the customer. Paste or point at the notes first.

Rewrite in plain language. Rewrite this in plainer language for a general audience. Good for anything technical going to people outside the team.

Rewrite for a senior audience. Rewrite this for a senior audience. Focus on outcomes, risks, and decisions needed. Leaders want the decision, not the history.

Turn text into action items. Turn this into bullet points with clear action items and owners where possible. Ask for owners and you get a list people can act on.

Draft a weekly status update. Draft a weekly status update for the project. Include accomplishments, current work, risks, decisions, and next steps. Use a professional business tone. Catch up on messages and the meeting recap first, then draft.

EXCEL

Find trends in a table. Review this spreadsheet and identify trends in project costs. The data covers the last six months and is for a planning discussion. Use this spreadsheet only. Present the top three trends, note any unusual changes, and explain the findings in plain language. "Use this spreadsheet only" keeps it from guessing.

Show insights in a table. Analyze this table and tell me the main trends, outliers, and changes over time. Format the data as a table with headers first.

Add a formula column. Add a new column called Total Cost that multiplies Hours by Hourly Rate for each row. Check a few rows by hand before you trust the column.

Explain a formula. Explain what the formula in column G does in plain language. Useful on a workbook someone else built.

Make a chart. Create a chart that shows total Amount by month. Name the measure and the grouping.

Turn action items into a table. Put these action items into a table with columns for Action Item, Owner, Status, and Due Date. Paste the action items from the meeting recap.

POWERPOINT

Make a first-draft deck from a document. Create a 10-slide presentation from this document for a team of project stakeholders. Use a professional, clear tone. Name the audience, the slide count, and the tone.

Add a slide. Add a slide that summarizes risks and next steps. A follow-up on the draft deck.

Add speaker notes. Add speaker notes for each slide with talking points for the presenter. Then read them once out loud.

Check before you trust it: open the sources, check names, numbers, and dates, read it once as the recipient.

Drafted with Copilot Chat on a personal Microsoft account, then edited by hand.